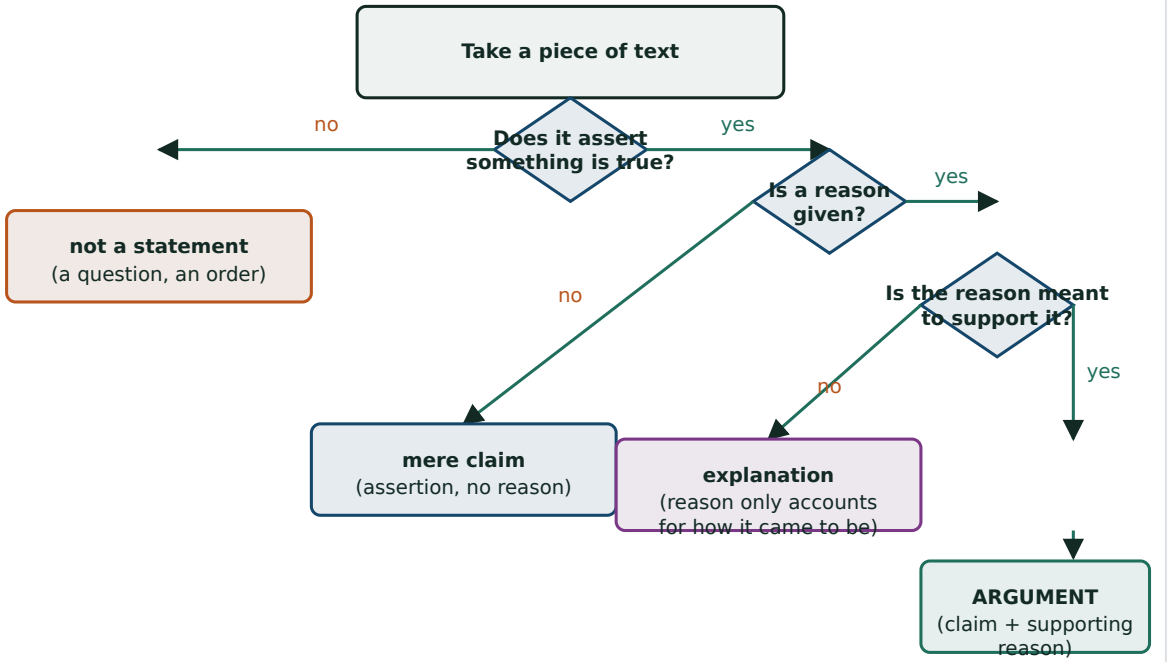
Draft - expert review pending

Note: This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but it is not reviewed yet. So, treat its sources and claims with care. You are encouraged to report errors and provide feedback.

Topic 1.4 - Statements, claims, issues and arguments

A real classroom situation

A teacher training college in Punjab sets this assignment: "Standardised testing improves the quality of education." Trainees must write a short response. One pupil writes, "I disagree." Another writes, "Standardised testing improves education because it lets the government compare schools and direct resources where they are most needed." A third writes, "Standardised testing is one form of assessment." The tutor wants to mark not just whether the trainees agree, but whether they can reason - and that means knowing which of the three is an argument.



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Unit of reasoning	The exact words from the paragraph "Workshop trainers say their method raises results by 30 per cent, so every school should adopt it."
statement	the whole sentence asserts something is true yes - it says something about what is the case
claim	"their method raises results by 30 per cent" the assertion that needs support
issue	"should every school adopt it?" a question people can reasonably disagree on
argument	the claim is supported by a reason meant to back it up yes - "raises results" is offered as the reason to adopt

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This topic gives you the vocabulary to tell those three apart, because you cannot evaluate reasoning until you can see what kind of reasoning you are looking at.

Explanation

Statements

A Statement is a sentence that claims something is (or is not) the case - something that can, at least in principle, be true or false. "The school has 400 pupils." "Monday is the first day of the week." Not every sentence is a statement: a question ("May I come in?") or an exclamation ("Well done!") makes no claim about what is true, so it is not a statement in the logical sense.

Claims

A Claim is a statement that someone puts forward as true, often in the face of possible disagreement. In practice the words "statement" and "claim" overlap a great deal. The useful difference is emphasis: calling something a *claim* signals that it needs support. When a colleague says "homework always improves learning", treating that as a claim means asking "what is the evidence?" rather than just accepting it.

Issues

An Issue is a question that invites more than one reasonable answer - something people can disagree about. "Should homework be set in grade 1?" is an issue. "How many pupils are in this class?" is not, because it has a single factual answer. Critical thinking spends its time on issues, because they are the questions that need reasoning rather than just looking something up.

Arguments

An Argument is the unit this whole topic has been building towards. An argument is **a claim plus at least one reason offered to support it**. The claim is the *conclusion*; the reasons are the *premises*. This is the meaning of "argument" in critical thinking, and it is not the everyday

meaning of "quarrel". A calm, well-supported case is an argument in the logical sense.

How do you tell an argument from a mere claim? Use a short decision path:

1. Does the text assert something is true? If not, it is not an argument.
2. Is a reason given for the assertion? If there is only a claim, it is a mere claim.
3. Is the reason *meant to support* the claim, or only to explain it? If the text says "X because Y" and Y is offered as evidence for X, that is an argument. If Y only explains *how* X came to be, that is an explanation, not an argument.

> **Common misconception.** Many trainees arrive believing "a claim and an argument are the same thing". The difference matters because an argument gives you more to judge. A claim alone ("streaming is unfair") asks only whether you agree. An argument ("streaming is unfair because it fixes labels too early and the evidence shows pupils move between levels") lets you ask whether the reasons actually support the conclusion - and that is where critical thinking gets to work.

> ## Activity: Argument or not?
>
> Work in pairs. About 20 minutes.
>
> For each of the three short reasoning below, decide whether it is an *argument*, a *mere claim*, or an *explanation*. Write one sentence each, naming the conclusion and the reason where they exist.
>
> 1. "Attendance is poor on Mondays because many pupils travel back from their villages on Monday morning."
> 2. "The school should start the week on Tuesday."

3. "Practical work helps pupils understand science, because it lets them see the idea rather than only hearing it."

For the two that are arguments, state the conclusion and the reason in your own words.

Check your understanding

1. **Remember** Name the four basic units of reasoning and state which one a critical thinker spends most time on.

2. **Understand** Explain the difference between a mere claim and an argument in one or two sentences.

3. **Apply** A colleague says, "These pupils cannot read Urdu because the textbook is in English." Is that reasoning an argument, a mere claim, or an explanation? Give one reason for your answer.

Summary

The basic units of reasoning are statements, claims, issues and arguments. An argument - a claim plus at least one supporting reason - is the unit critical thinking evaluates. Telling an argument from a mere claim or an explanation lets you ask the question that matters: do the reasons actually support the conclusion?

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can distinguish a statement, a claim, an issue and an argument.
- [ ] I can use a decision path to decide whether a piece of text is an argument.
- [ ] I can explain why an argument gives a critical thinker more to evaluate than a claim.

Try this at your practicum school

Take one paragraph from a textbook you are using or from a notice in the staffroom. Identify whether it contains an argument, a mere claim, or an explanation. If it is an argument, write down the conclusion and the reason in your own words.

Summative task

Here is a short piece of reasoning: **"Morning assembly should be shortened. The first period after assembly always loses ten minutes, and the term timetable is already too full to spare them."** Write a short paragraph (80-120 words) that (a) states whether this is an argument, a claim or an explanation, (b) gives one reason for your classification, and (c) names the conclusion and the reason if it is an argument.

> **Mini-rubric**

Criterion	Levels
Classification	0-2: correctly classifies and gives a valid reason / correct classification but weak reason / wrong.
Use of scenario evidence	0-3: cites specific words from the text to justify the classification / vague / none. (**Analyze**: ties the classification to the actual reasoning in the scenario.)
Clarity	0:2: paragraph coherent and within word band / unclear or over length.

Further reading

Bassham, G., Irwin, W., Nardone, H., & Wallace, J. M. (2010). *Critical thinking: A student's introduction* (4th ed.). McGraw-Hill. Chapters 7-8 introduce the units of reasoning - statements, claims, issues and arguments - drawn on in this topic.

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Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback